Las Casas Vs. Sepúlveda

The 16th-century between Bartolomé de las Casas and Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda debated whether it was morally justified to use military force to secure Spanish control over the indigenous people of the Americas based on the dispute of whether they were natural slaves or not, representing a pivotal moment in the ethical and theological discourse of the Spanish Empire. In this case, we define natural slaves in the proper and strict sense, that is people who were "strangers to reason" demonstrated by their lack of laws, friendship, commerce, etc. In this paper, I will first lay an overview of the dispute and outline the thoughts of Las Casas and Sepúlveda regarding whether the indigenous people were or were not natural slaves in the proper and strict sense. Then, I will argue for Las Casas' opinions while pointing out flaws in Sepúlveda's.

During the dispute between Las Casas and Sepúlveda, they agreed on the growing presence of Spain in the Americas, following the basic truths of the Roman Catholic faiths and that the conversion of the indigenous to this faith was beneficial to the Spanish, and the indigenous as the natives followed barbaric practices that involved deaths of approximately 100,000 people every year. Although Las Casas argued that the enslavement and violent treatment of the natives was unjust, Sepúlveda defended the Spanish conquest based on the natives' inferiority in rational capacities.

Understanding Las Casas' perspective, it was commonly accepted that the only way humans lacked rational capacities was as an underlying symptom of some disease or problem. Las Casas' central argument was that the indigenous people were not natural slaves by definition as they were not defective (Las Casas 38) and maintained law and order. Even though their law and order differs from that of the Roman Catholic faith, Las Casas claimed that the natives had their own systems of power structures, societal structures, culture, etc. which proved that they governed their lives in light of reason. He argued that their corrupt practices weren't inherent flaws but merely products of their circumstances which could be altered with the introduction of proper religious instruction and integration into Christian society (Las Casas 42). He condemned violence and emphasised his belief that forced conversion is merely performative causing them to resent the catholic faith and opposing the Christian golden rule to "love thy neighbour as thyself". (Las Casas 39)

On the other hand, Sepúlveda believed that because of their barbaric practices, the natives' moral reasoning capacities were inferior; thus the conquest was justified by the doctrine of war (Sepúlveda's Ninth Objection) as the Spaniards would put an end to the murderous activities, bringing civilization. Therefore, Sepúlveda argued for the war as a necessary measure to save the natives' souls from eternal damnation as given their social circumstances, it didn't seem likely that they would be open to conversion. Sepúlveda disagreed with Las Casas' about the extent to which natives' rational capacities had been made defective by their social circumstances (Sepúlveda's Eighth Objection). The natives' institutionalised violations of morality were instilled into all the indigenous people; thus, they believed in public customs that approved of atrocities.

Sepúlveda's stance leads me to question whether all groups of people that are equally rational as deemed by others but have less power and different morals than them are conquerable according to Sepúlveda. If we follow the common belief that all humans that are born with no defects inherently have

rational capabilities then is there an objective answer between which of the two sets of morals must be followed? Sepúlveda condemns practices of cannibalism and human sacrifice, his thoughts align to sacrificing the natives in light of greater good according to his faith's beliefs, meanwhile, the natives follow the same logical procedure according to their faith's beliefs. Alternatively, Las Casas proposes a more respectful stance that doesn't undervalue the others' intelligence. While it would require lots of effort to persuade such a large group with deeply rooted cultures to reboot their belief system, if successful the result would be far superior in quality. It would educate through example, thus following the Christian's idea of treating others how one would like to be treated themself. Another contradiction I found in Sepúlveda's argument is that while the indigenous people's inherent rational capacities were affected by their institutionalised enforcement of morals and social conditions, Sepúlveda did not think the same process could be used to reverse this conditioning.

In conclusion, while both Las Casas and Sepúlveda make thorough arguments, my beliefs align more with Las Casas' as the quality of his method along with the minimal physical damage would not only demonstrate the truths of the Roman Catholic faith but also defeat the effectiveness of Sepúlveda's inhumane quick fix solution. Overall, I believe that valuing the equality of humans and human life in general instils a mindset that can timelessly aid in the interactions between groups with differing values.